

white consumers, on the other hand, incorporated the use of coupons into the image of what a stay-at-home spouse should do. They were confident enough in their affluence not to feel threatened by the attitude of clerks. Those most sensitive to the criticism received at the checkout (and perhaps from the customers behind them in line) are less likely to be willing to use coupons because they view them as a symbol of financial need.

So, in essence, my friend's husband, who forbade coupon use, was not confident enough in his own financial status to allow his wife to use coupons. I, on the other hand, have definitely been encouraged by enthusiastic cashiers and even praise from customers waiting in line behind me. I've even had a man or two express a wish to be married to me, much to my chagrin, and their wife's extreme annoyance.

On the other hand, I have also experienced negative reactions to my coupon use: the eye rolls, exaggerated sighs, and once, a woman behind me in line (to whom I had offered coupons to use on her order), eyed me up and down in derision, and asked "Do I look like I need to use coupons?"

